

CORE FORMULA

Exact phrase -> small comment -> natural follow-up. -> You called it 'oddly freeing' — freeing how? -> 'Hidden rules' is a good phrase. What are you noticing? -> When you say 'messy', do you mean emotionally or logistically? -> 'Not quite right' sounds specific. What was off?

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Pick one distinctive word they used and ask '[word] how?' or 'What do you mean by [word]?'

BEST FOR

- Keeping a conversation going without asking generic questions
- Deepening small talk naturally
- Making someone feel precisely understood
- Networking and professional conversations where nuance matters
- Conflict, when you want to understand the exact concern
- Dating or social chemistry, when their wording reveals personality
- Digital and text replies where one exact phrase can create warmth
- Building callbacks for later in the conversation

PHRASE BANK

Quick · Short one-liners

- "Weird how?"
- "Messy how?"
- "Freeing in what way?"
- "What do you mean by 'stuck'?"
- "When you say 'intense', what kind of intense?"
- "What made it feel 'off'?"
- "'Heavy' how?"
- "Say more about 'clunky'?"

Warm · Curious and warm

- "That word sounds like it matters."
- "'Oddly freeing' is interesting — what made it feel that way?"
- "I want to ask about the word you used there."
- "That sounds more specific than it first seemed."
- "There's something in that phrase I want to understand."
- "You said 'relief' — I'd love to hear more about that."

Professional · Work and decisions

- "When you say 'misaligned', what's the part that isn't lining up?"
- "'Hidden constraints' sounds important. What constraints are you seeing?"
- "You described it as 'fragile' — where's the fragility?"
- "What does 'cleaner' look like in this context?"
- "When you say 'blocked', is that a people issue, a process issue, or timing?"
- "You called the plan 'ambitious' — ambitious where, specifically?"

Conflict-softening · Understand the concern

- "When you say it felt 'dismissive', what did that look like from your side?"

- "'Unfair' is the key word I'm hearing. What part felt unfair?"
- "I don't want to miss your meaning. When you say 'ignored', what was the moment that felt like that?"
- "'Pressured' matters here. What made it feel pressured?"
- "Help me understand your word 'disrespected' — what was the part that landed that way?"

Social / dating · Chemistry and personality

- "'Chaotic but fun' is a strong phrase. What happened?"
- "You said 'weirdly wholesome' — I need that story."
- "'Comfortably awkward' is very specific. Explain."
- "You called it 'your kind of strange' — what kind is that?"
- "That phrase has personality. What do you mean by it?"

Digital / text · One exact phrase back

- "'Oddly freeing' caught my eye — freeing how?"
- "When you say 'messy', do you mean emotionally or logistically?"
- "'Hidden rules' is a great phrase. What are the rules?"
- "That 'not quite right' bit sounds important."
- "Curious what you mean by 'strangely calm'."

High-status / busy person · Crisp and to the point

- "When you say 'risk', which risk matters most?"
- "You mentioned 'quality drift' — where are you seeing it?"
- "'Decision latency' is the phrase I'm picking up. What's causing the delay?"
- "When you say 'not worth it', is the issue effort, timing, or payoff?"
- "You said 'good enough' — good enough for now, or good enough to ship?"

Shy / guarded person · Optional and low-pressure

- "You used the word 'strange' — only if you want to, strange how?"
- "I might be picking up the wrong word, but 'tiring' stood out."
- "No pressure to go into it, but what did you mean by 'heavy'?"
- "You said 'fine-ish' — that sounds like there's a caveat."
- "'Draining' stood out — you don't have to unpack it, but I noticed."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: How was it?

Better: What was it like?

Best: You called it 'oddly freeing' — freeing how?

2. Weak: Why?

Better: Why did that matter?

Best: 'Not quite right' sounds specific. What was off?

3. Weak: Tell me more.

Better: What happened next?

Best: 'Hidden rules' is the phrase I want to ask about. What were the rules?

4. Weak: That sounds bad.

Better: That sounds frustrating.

Best: When you say it felt 'dismissive', what did that look like from your side?

5. Weak: Interesting.

Better: That's interesting.

Best: 'A strange relief' is interesting — was it relief because something ended, or because something became clearer?

DECISION TREE

If They expand warmly

Reflect the meaning, then ask one more follow-up if the energy is still there.

"So it was less about the work and more about the people?"

If They correct your interpretation

Accept the correction quickly and carry on with their version.

"Got it — not X, more Y."

If They seem mocked or analysed

Repair your tone and name your intent.

"I meant that as curiosity, not a gotcha."

If They give a vague answer

Offer two gentle options rather than pushing.

"Do you mean X, or more Y?"

If They become vulnerable

Slow down, reflect, and don't reach for a joke too quickly.

"That sounds like it mattered."

If They ask you back

Answer briefly, then hand the thread back to them.

"For me it was similar — but what was it like for you?"

If They say it was just a throwaway word

Drop it gracefully and move to something lighter.

"Fair enough — no need to unpack it."

SCENARIOS

Casual conversation

Pick the unusual word and ask about it lightly, without making it a big deal. — "'Chaotic but fun' sounds like there's a story."

Professional conversation

Use their exact words to clarify criteria, risk or constraints. — "When you say 'fragile', where is the fragility?"

Conflict

Pick up the complaint word without debating it. — "When you say it felt 'dismissive', what was the moment that landed that way?"

Digital or text

Quote one phrase briefly and ask a concise follow-up. — "'Strange relief' caught my eye — relief how?"

High-status person

Use their exact terminology to show you understand the frame. — "You mentioned 'quality drift' — where is it showing up first?"

Shy or guarded person

Make it optional and low-pressure so there's an easy exit. — "You said 'heavy' — no pressure, but heavy how?"

Dating or social chemistry

Pick phrases with personality and respond playfully. — "'Your kind of strange' is a sentence that needs explaining."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- The word is too private, shame-laden, traumatic, or potentially embarrassing to repeat directly
- They used the word jokingly and repeating it would sound like mockery
- You are tempted to use their wording as evidence against them
- You have already mirrored or repeated several words and it is starting to feel mechanical
- The person seems guarded, rushed, or annoyed by being analysed
- A direct response, apology, boundary, or answer is more appropriate than further exploration

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Notice the wording

Through one day, spot a single distinctive word or phrase in each real conversation — a vivid adjective, metaphor, label or contrast. Just notice it; don't act on it yet.

Day 2 — Say the move aloud

Say the minimum viable move aloud three times until it sounds natural: '[word] how?' and 'What do you mean by [word]?'

Day 3 — Pick one up

In one real conversation, pick up a single distinctive word with a short, natural question. Use it once only, and watch how they respond.

Day 4 — Comment before the question

Practise adding a light comment before the question — "'Oddly freeing' is interesting — freeing how?" — so it lands as curiosity, not an interview.

Day 5 — Reflect the meaning

After they explain, reflect the underlying point back in one sentence: 'So it was less about the work, more about the people.'

Day 6 — Recover from a miss

Deliberately over-read a phrase, then practise one recovery line out loud: 'I was picking up your word, not trying to pin you to it.'

Day 7 — Use a callback

Pick up a phrase early in a conversation, then return to it later — 'That sounds like another hidden-rules moment' — and notice whether they feel remembered.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I pick one word rather than repeat too much?
- Did my tone sound curious, not mocking?
- Did I ask from their frame rather than impose mine?
- Did I let them correct me?
- Did I contribute after one or two follow-ups, instead of only asking?
- Did the conversation become more precise or warmer?